Explicit vocabulary teaching

Developing keystone vocabulary

Use explicit vocabulary teaching when disciplinary language is essential to understanding and expressing an idea. Students need to hear, say, use and revisit the word in context.

How to do it well

1 Identify the essential term. Choose vocabulary needed to understand the content or produce a precise response.

2 Say and explain it. Model pronunciation, give a concise definition and connect it to a familiar idea without distorting the meaning.

3 Show boundaries. Use examples, non-examples and any important contrast with the everyday meaning.

4 Rehearse active use. Students say, write and apply the term in a sentence, explanation or comparison; prompt precision where necessary.

5 Return later. Include the term in retrieval and new contexts so students can recognise and use it without the original prompt.

What this sounds like

“In science, work means energy transferred when a force moves an object. Use that definition to explain which of these examples counts as work.”

Classroom example. In Business Studies, pupils learn the disciplinary meaning of profit and contrast it with revenue. They use the terms in a short explanation and classify examples before calculating. Later retrieval asks for the distinction through a new scenario. Correct use depends on meaning rather than recognising a copied definition.

Top tips that make the technique work

Select keystone vocabulary. Prioritise words that unlock the current concept and recur in later learning.

Address familiar meanings. Words such as “work”, “power” and “significant” can have a different disciplinary meaning.

Use morphology when useful. A prefix or root can support meaning, but it should not replace the subject definition.

Require use in a full idea. Correct pronunciation alone does not show that a student understands the term.

Revisit through varied cues. Ask for a definition, an example, a non-example or an explanation using the word.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Teach a precise meaning and examples.	Giving a long list of definitions to copy once.
Build repeated use into explanation and practice.	Accepting the correct word in an otherwise inaccurate explanation.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Tips for Teachers - Alex Quigley on keystone vocabulary